“allied to each other.” Kissinger told Nixon that Beijing saw Delhi as Moscow’s “principal agent” and one of “two enemies in its pantheon.”[38]

Nixon, in turn, told David Bruce, who was designated as the head of the new American liaison office in China, that the “Chinese must be reassured,” including on the India front. The Sino-American relationship was “the key to peace in the world” and gave the US leverage with the Soviet Union.[39] Thus the administration continued to discuss India-Pakistan issues with Beijing. Kissinger reiterated assurances that the US would make no overall changes to its South Asia policy without discussion with China. The US would also continue to try to assist Pakistan economically and help Islamabad acquire arms. Kissinger also kept Chinese officials informed of developments in US-India relations, as well as US-Soviet discussions regarding the extent of Moscow’s commitment to Delhi.[40]

American policymakers also used India to highlight to Chinese policymakers why the US was an important friend to have. Despite what he told Indian officials, Kissinger did not play down India-Soviet cooperation in conversations with Chinese officials. Instead, for example, he highlighted it as a reason that China should not want too hasty an American withdrawal from Southeast Asia. He also did not assuage Chinese concerns about India’s objectives vis-à-vis Pakistan, concurring that Delhi would “encourage” breakaway movements in that country. American officials also noted that India was trying to create a “great imbalance” in terms of strength in the broader region.[41] Kissinger asserted that the US would not accept this, but was left on the defensive when, in November 1974, the Chinese foreign minister pointed out that Kissinger had just given a speech acknowledging Indian leadership and strength in the subcontinent.[42]

The administration was aware that Chinese officials were watching the US interactions with India. Thus, while noting internally that the US was “anxious for steady improvement” with India, Kissinger emphasized, “We don’t want too high a visibility which might upset the Chinese who loathe the Indians.”[43] In meetings with Chinese officials, Kissinger explained the rapprochement with India in terms of Chinese interests. Kissinger assured Zhou that he had “never been an admirer of Indian policy.” However, he indicated that the US would try to improve relations with India slowly in order to prevent Delhi from getting even closer to Moscow. With Nixon’s and then Ford’s acquiescence, Kissinger continued to highlight that